

process of digging into the data to determine if something is merely an intriguing one-off, or emblematic of a nascent trend. A good story should be considered preliminary evidence, the start of a more serious inquiry.

In other words, the plural of anecdote, to be more precise, *might be* valid data leading to a potentially significant conclusion. For that reason, when an unusual anecdote captures one's attention, it shouldn't be casually dismissed, lest a deeper truth be missed.

Consider the ramifications of this for how analysts, economists, fund managers do their jobs. Algorithms are increasingly replacing repetitive tasks, and for people who work in finance, this is potentially an existential risk to their careers. The ability to identify something via an anecdotal observation, then use data to discover a new idea or concept, might be relatively immune from the machines coming to replace you. So take heart: It might be a while—if ever—before AI and big data are sophisticated enough to do just that.



The past ten chapters are a good start to understand economic innumeracy. In our next section, we are going to look at some shocking truths about the markets.

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[170](#) Daniel Kahneman, *Thinking, Fast and Slow* (Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2011).

[171](#) Amos Tversky and Daniel Kahneman, "Availability: A Heuristic for Judging Frequency and Probability," The Hebrew University of Jerusalem and the Oregon Research Institute, *Cognitive Psychology*, Vol. 5, Issue 2, pp. 207–232 (Science Direct, 1973). See also: Amos Tversky and Daniel Kahneman, "Judgment under Uncertainty: Heuristics and Biases," *Science New Series*, Vol. 185, No. 4157, pp. 1124–1131 (American Association for the Advancement of Science, 1974).

[172](#)

Peter Benchley, *Jaws* (Doubleday, 1974).

[173](#) "Preventable Tragedies: Unintentional Shootings by Children," Everytown Research and policy (last updated: April 26, 2023). See also: Suzy Khimm, "Children unintentionally shot and killed at least 157 people last year, Everytown says," NBC News (March 18, 2024).

[174](#) Raymond Wolfinger (1931–2015).

[175](#) David Smith, "The plural of anecdote is data, after all," *Revolutions* (April 6, 2011).